Playground Purgatory

By Colin Nissan

ANNA: Is that your little guy over there?

SARA: Yeah, that's Sebastian.

ANNA: What a cutie. That's my Tessa on the slide.

SARA: She's adorable.

ANNA: I feel like I've definitely seen you here before. I'm Anna.

SARA: You look familiar, too. I'm Sara.

ANNA: We're here a lot, Tessa and I.

SARA: Yeah, this is like a second home for Sebastian and me.

ANNA: This place is such a lifesaver.

SARA: Total lifesaver.

ANNA: We're here every day. Sometimes twice.

SARA: Tell me about it, we were here for ten hours yesterday.

ANNA: I really treasure the time that Tessa and I spend here.

SARA: Wouldn't trade it for the world.

ANNA: I'm always so happy when I'm here, and never feel strange or despondent.

SARA: Me, too. So happy. The sound of all the kids laughing and screaming is so joyous, and doesn't sound anything like nails on a chalkboard.

ANNA: I've never cried behind that tree.

SARA: Me neither. *(Pause)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Ask people what they think about SAHM's*
ACTRESS 2: *That's Stay-At-Home Moms*
ACTRESS 1: *. . . and you'll get a variety of answers:*
ACTRESS 2: *They're lazy.*
ACTRESS 1: *They're making the best decision of their lives.*
ACTRESS 2: *They're not contributing to society.*
ACTRESS 1: *They're making a great sacrifice to stay home and nurture their kids day in and day out.*
ACTRESS 2: *There's no shortage of opinions about women who stay home to raise their kids.*
ACTRESS 1: *But what's it **REALLY** like to spend all day, every day **ALONE** with your toddler? (a variety of expressions pass over both faces)*
ACTRESS 2: *It's purgatory . . .*
ACTRESS 1: *Yeah . . . purgatory . . . an extremely unpleasant experience that causes suffering*
ACTRESS 2: *There's always the playground . . .*
TOGETHER: *Playground Purgatory by Colin Nissan*

ANNA: Tessa! Tess! Come on over here and put on your coat, O.K., sweetheart? It's chilly out, and you need to put on your coat, O.K.? Your coat needs to go on your body. The fabric needs to cover your torso to help you maintain a proper internal temperature, or you'll die, O.K., pumpkin? You'll die of hypothermia, right here at the playground, unless you put your coat on. Your body's going to start shutting down soon. It'll feel like you're getting sleepy for nap time, but you'll actually be getting sleepy for dying. ***Get your coat on!*** *(Pause)* Is that your little guy over there?

SARA: Yeah, that's Sebastian.

ANNA: What a cutie. That's my Tessa on the slide.

SARA: She's adorable.

ANNA: Wait. I'm sorry . . . did I already ask you that?

SARA: Did you? I don't think so.

ANNA: I'm so embarrassed.

SARA: Did I answer you again?

ANNA: I . . . don't know. *(Pause)* I feel funny sometimes.

SARA: It's this place. It's evil.

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ANNA: I'm scared.

SARA: There are dark forces here. Powerful forces.

ANNA: And yet it's the only place that makes sense to me anymore. Here and my bathroom.

SARA: Sometimes, when I'm in the sandbox, I can feel myself sinking, like something is pulling me down. I can feel the sand slowly surrounding me, suffocating me, and it feels good. *(Pause)* We should totally do a playdate sometime!

ANNA: Oh my God, it would be so great to do a playdate!

SARA: Is that applesauce on your shirt?

ANNA: This? No, this is throw-up. Tessa regurgitated on me. But, applesauce or throw-up, what's the difference, really? They're both just things that get on your shirt that you lose the will to wipe off after a certain point, because either way you're going to give yourself a haircut with a kitchen knife, right?

SARA: So true.

ANNA: There's also string cheese in my hair, not sure if you saw that.

SARA: Last night, I found a cheddar Goldfish in my *bra.*

ANNA: Wow.

SARA: Yeah.

ANNA: In it?

SARA: Right in it. *(Pause)*

ANNA: Tessa! Honey! Share the slide, Honey Bear! We don't own the slide, O.K.? We have to share, because if we don't society will collapse and we'll become no better than animals, tearing one another limb from limb just to survive. This playground and everything around it will deteriorate into a dystopian war zone, a lawless heap of smoldering ash. And guess what dystopian war zones don't have? Slides. ***Share the slide!*** *(Pause)*

SARA: Hey, look who just walked in.

ANNA: Where?

SARA: Over there, by Nanny Alley.

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ANNA: Oh boy.

SARA: Stay-at-home Hottie McBjörn.

ANNA: Daddy's home.

SARA: Daddy's home, all right.

ANNA: Bad day for me to not shower.

SARA: Bad day for me to be twice my college weight.

ANNA: Oh my God, have you seen his wife?

SARA: No! You?

ANNA: She made an appearance here. Once. Working mom.

SARA: So sad.

ANNA: I know.

SARA: And?

ANNA: Meh.

SARA: He deserves more than that.

ANNA: So much more.

SARA: He's hurting.

ANNA: You'd never know it. He's so brave. And able. I saw him tie a water balloon with one hand before.

SARA: I saw him make a diaper out of leaves. *(Pause)*

ANNA: Well, well, well, look over there by the monkey bars.

SARA: If it isn't Hot Skinny Mom.

ANNA: She's got some nerve. Ms. My Baby Weight Just Vanished Because I'm a Terrible Person.

SARA: Ms. I Carry a Yoga Mat on My Back Because You Never Know When I Might Just Start Doing Yoga.

ANNA: Ms. My Hair Is Washed.

SARA: Ms. I Went to Law School but Decided to Work Part Time at an Inner-City Nonprofit for At-Risk Youth So I Can Give Back to the Community Because I'm So-o-o-o-o-o-o Skinny!

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ANNA: What?

SARA: Sorry, I don't know what that was. *(Pause)*

ANNA: I love her outfit.

SARA: It's so cute I want to tear her little arms off.

ANNA: Tessa? Tess, honey! It's time for lunch, O.K.? Let's take a break and have something to eat now, because Mommy's hungry, too, and Mommy can't eat her lunch until you've eaten yours, because, as you know, Mommy's lunch is just the remnants of your lunch—your toast crusts, your milk backwash, and, with any luck, a frantic lick of your half-eaten yogurt container. O.K., Sugarplum? ***Come eat your lunch!*** *(Pause)*

ANNA: Such a beautiful day here today.

SARA: It's perfect.

ANNA: Not a cloud in the sky.

SARA: Never is.

ANNA: I'm Anna, by the way.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Colin Nissan
ISBN: Magazine
Publisher: The New Yorker
Date (Month/Year): May 18, 2015

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier

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